UNDERSTANDING THE MIND BETTER

DR. SONIA LAL GUPTA ON NEUROLOGY, EMPATHY, AND THE METRO VISION

Despite medical advances, neurological health remains widely misunderstood–often delayed in diagnosis and clouded by stigma. In this conversation, Dr. Sonia Lal Gupta unpacks key concerns in the field, from shifting disease patterns to the role of empathy in care. A senior neurologist and Director at Metro Group of Hospitals, Dr. Sonia brings both clinical depth and administrative insight to the conversation, shaped by years of global experience and a leadership role in one of North India's leading healthcare networks.



Dr. Sonia Lal Gupta
Director, Metro Group of Hospitals

Q. We have seen a significant shift in how neurological health is understood, even among otherwise well-informed individuals. What, in your view, are the key gaps that still need addressing?

The brain remains one of the least understood organs. Despite medical progress, neurological conditions still carry stigma, hence patients delay seeking treatment. Though rooted in similar chemical imbalances as conditions like diabetes or hypertension, brain disorders are often seen differently. Yet many are treatable with medication—awareness, however, remains low.

Stroke, in particular, is an area where timely action can make a life-altering difference. If patients reach a hospital within 4.5 hours of symptom onset—such as sudden weakness in the face or limbs—they can be given clot-busting medication or transferred to a tertiary centre for intervention. But due to limited awareness, few in India get timely care.

Q. Over the years, what changes have you observed in terms of diagnosis or presentation of neurological disorders? Are patterns shifting?

Diagnosis rates have improved with greater awareness. However, lifestyle changes like prolonged screen time, sedentary routines, and rising stress have contributed to a surge in anxiety, depression, and posture-related issues, particularly among younger people. Conditions once seen in older adults, such as strokes and memory disorders, are now occurring earlier. Chronic stress disrupts hormonal balance, compounding neurological challenges. So while more patients are seeking help, we're also witnessing a real rise in incidence.

Q. Building on what you mentioned earlier, how can early diagnosis be approached in real-world situations?

Each disorder presents differently. Take headaches—there are over 300 types. Migraines, often mistaken for sinus issues, are typically marked by sensitivity to light or sound. Tremors, especially those in one hand at rest, should be clinically evaluated, not ignored or Googled.

Even common complaints like tingling hands may indicate carpal tunnel syndrome, especially in those using computers extensively. The real red flags, though, are sudden-onset symptoms: severe headaches, weakness, or speech issues. Most neurological symptoms develop gradually. Anything sudden is an emergency and needs urgent hospital care.

Q. Could you take us back to the origins of Metro Hospital?

Metro Group of Hospitals was founded in 1997 by Dr. Purshotam Lal, a Padma Bhushan awardee and renowned interventional cardiologist. Coming from a modest background, he studied and worked abroad before returning to India with a vision: to offer high-quality, affordable healthcare.

Starting with a single hospital in Noida, Metro has since expanded across North India, Faridabad, Meerut, Haridwar, Rewari, and more, with dedicated centres for oncology and multispecialty care. We're also developing teleconsultation platforms to serve Tier 2 and 3 regions.

Q. How is Metro Hospitals reimagining neurological care? What steps are being taken to improve accessibility and patient experience?

At Metro, clinical care is complemented by compassion. As someone involved in both treatment and administration, I believe patient experience starts with empathy. A kind word or a reassuring tone can ease anxiety even before medication begins.

We also place great emphasis on training paramedical and nursing staff, as they are integral to the overall experience. Empathy, communication, and cultural sensitivity are key, more so in the context of medical tourism.

Q. Speaking of which, with India emerging as a hub for medical tourism, how is your group contributing to this space?

India provides quality healthcare at affordable prices, something many patients from developed countries struggle to access quickly. At Metro, we offer advanced treatments across specialities like oncology, neurology, cardiology, and gastroenterology.

We have also expanded internationally with a polyclinic in Oman and a 250-bed hospital underway. To support international patients, our teams are trained to provide culturally sensitive care and build trust from the first interaction.

Q. You now operate at the intersection of clinical practice, communication, and leadership. How has this multifaceted role shaped your journey?

It is both a privilege and a responsibility. Being the daughter of the founders means inheriting a legacy, but also helping evolve it. After nearly a decade abroad, choosing to return wasn't easy, but it felt necessary.

Today, Metro is poised for its next phase of growth. While I continue to practise as a neurologist, I also look forward to shaping the institution alongside my husband, Dr. Sameer Gupta, my brother, Dr. Sahil Lal, and the larger leadership team.